

Briefing note for course leaders and tutors

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Talking with students about artificial intelligence (AI) in learning and assessment

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Background

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is a fast-moving area, and expectations and practices will continue to develop. While it may not always be possible to determine whether or how AI has been used, such tools may form part of the wider support students draw on in their learning process. Conversations with students can help them to think critically about how they use AI, what supports their learning, and where independent thinking and judgement remain important.

Students may encounter different approaches to AI across subjects, tutors, courses and colleges. They may find that their peers have different expectations or different degrees of latitude in their use of AI. While these differences may initially be confusing, they can reflect variation in disciplinary approaches, educational purposes and teaching contexts. Making this explicit can help students understand how differing approaches to AI sit within Oxford's personalised learning environment, where teaching and academic guidance respond to the subject, context and individual student.

This briefing note has been developed to support course leaders and tutors in encouraging conversations about AI throughout a course. The aim is to use students' questions about AI as opportunities to discuss learning, assessment and disciplinary practice, helping them to understand the reasons for different expectations about AI use, and develop the judgement needed to make informed decisions during their studies. It should be read alongside relevant course, departmental, faculty and college guidance on AI, as well as the CTL's briefing note [Developing categories for AI use in summative assessment and communicating with students.](#)

At a glance: key considerations for course leaders

Key consideration	Questions to consider
Identify opportunities to discuss AI	When are conversations about AI likely to have the greatest educational value?
Discuss AI in the subject and professional practice context	How does AI relate to scholarship and, where appropriate, professional practice within the subject?
Discuss AI in relation to learning	How can conversations help students understand when AI supports learning, and when it may reduce opportunities to learn?
Discuss AI in relation to assessment	How can students understand why expectations for AI use may differ across learning activities and assessments, and between subjects and colleges?
Review conversations about AI	How will conversations remain useful and relevant as students' questions emerge, and AI continues to evolve rapidly?

Throughout this briefing note, 'conversations' refers to the routine discussions that take place between students and tutors, lecturers and other teaching staff during tutorials, classes, practical teaching sessions and assessment opportunities. These conversations need not be separate teaching sessions but may arise naturally within existing teaching arrangements.

Each key consideration is discussed below, including *Possible questions for discussion with students*. These are intended as prompts to support discussion and may be adapted to suit the subject, teaching context and students.

Identify opportunities to discuss AI

Students are likely to begin their course with different experiences of AI and different assumptions about how it should be used in higher education. Conversations about AI are likely to arise naturally during tutorials, classes, practical teaching sessions, formative work and assessment opportunities. These discussions are often most valuable when they are open and exploratory, allowing students to share their own experiences and questions.

Staff do not need to have all the answers – these conversations provide opportunities to explore questions together within the context of the subject.

Points for consideration

- when students are most likely to need guidance about AI
- where conversations fit naturally within tutorials, classes and other teaching opportunities
- opportunities to revisit discussions throughout the course
- how students can share their own experiences of using AI
- opportunities for reflection following assessment activities
- where students can find further guidance on AI, such as existing course or college guidance

Possible questions for discussion with students

- What experience have you had of using AI so far?
- What have you found helpful?
- What have you found less helpful?
- What questions do you have about using AI in your studies?
- What would help you to feel more confident about using AI appropriately?

Discuss AI in the subject and professional practice context

Students benefit from understanding AI within the context of their subject, rather than as a separate topic. Conversations about AI provide opportunities to explore how knowledge is created, evaluated and applied within the discipline, how AI is influencing scholarship (and, where relevant, professional practice), and where human expertise and judgement remain essential. These discussions help students understand that expectations about AI are shaped by the ways knowledge is developed and used within the subject.

Points for consideration

- how tutors, lecturers and other teaching staff can discuss AI within the context of the subject
- how AI is influencing scholarship and, where relevant, professional practice
- where human expertise and judgement remain essential

- how students develop the subject knowledge needed to judge when AI can be relied upon, and when further enquiry is needed
- how ethical and professional responsibilities relate to the use of AI within the subject, and how this may change as AI evolves

Possible questions for discussion with students

- How is AI changing the subject?
- What kinds of expertise remain essential?
- What knowledge do you need before you can judge whether an AI response is reliable?
- How might AI be used in professional practice?

Discuss AI in relation to learning

Students often ask whether they can use AI in their coursework. Tutors, lecturers and other teaching staff are well placed to encourage conversations that move beyond questions of what is permitted, by helping students to understand what they are trying to learn and why different learning activities matter.

These conversations can help students develop the academic judgement needed to decide when AI might support their learning, when they need to undertake the work independently, and why different learning activities may lead to different decisions about AI use.

Points for consideration

- what students should be able to do independently of AI by the time they graduate
- which aspects of learning are particularly valuable for students to undertake themselves
- how AI may support practice, feedback, revision or questioning
- when AI may reduce opportunities for students to develop understanding or judgement
- how students might reflect on their approaches to learning and develop their own academic judgement

Possible questions for discussion with students

- What are you trying to learn through this activity?
- What thinking do you need to do yourself?
- How might AI help you learn?
- When might the use of AI reduce opportunities to develop your understanding?
- How will you know that you genuinely understand this topic?
- When and how should you declare your use of AI in formative work, e.g. essays or problem sheets for tutorials?

Discuss AI in relation to assessment

There is no single institutional expectation about student use of AI. Students often ask why they may be encouraged to use AI in one context but discouraged from using it in another. Conversations about assessment can help them understand that different learning activities and assessments have different educational purposes, and that expectations for AI use reflect those purposes.

Points for consideration

- how tutors, lecturers and other teaching staff explain the different purposes of tutorials, independent study, formative work and summative assessment
- what aspects of student learning are different assessments designed to evidence
- why expectations for AI may differ across learning activities and assessments
- what the course, departmental, faculty and college guidance says about AI use in summative assessment
- what explanation students may need to understand the educational rationale for different categories of AI use

Possible questions for discussion with students

- What guidance does your course provide on permitted AI use in summative assessment?
- How are you required to declare your AI use in assessments?
- What learning is this assessment task (e.g. essay, practical, dissertation) designed to assess?

- Why might expectations for AI differ across assessments?
- What knowledge or skills are you expected to demonstrate independently, and what steps are you taking to understand how AI use might affect your ability to demonstrate these?
- What would help you understand the reasons behind the course expectations for using AI?

Review conversations about AI

Students' questions and experiences are likely to change throughout their studies as AI continues to develop. Course leaders may therefore wish to encourage colleagues to revisit conversations about AI periodically, and use the outcomes of these to refine course, departmental, faculty and college guidance.

Reviewing these conversations may also help identify common questions, misconceptions and emerging issues to address through future teaching and locally customised guidance.

Points for consideration

- what questions students are asking
- whether there are any recurring misconceptions
- whether there are new developments relevant to the use of AI in the subject
- whether course, departmental, faculty and college guidance remains clear and useful
- whether further conversations would benefit students
- whether opportunities might be provided for colleagues to share practice and build confidence in discussing AI with students

Possible questions for discussion with students

- Has your thinking about AI changed during the course of your studies to date?
- What have you learned about your own approaches to studying?
- What advice would you give to new students studying this subject?
- What further conversations about AI would you find helpful?

- What knowledge and skills would help you use and evaluate AI outputs more effectively?

Further resources

- [Centre for Teaching and Learning: AI in Teaching and Learning](#)
- [AI Competence Centre \(AICC\): Training for students and staff](#)
- [Exams and assessment framework](#)

Acknowledgements

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Version history

This briefing note will be reviewed annually to reflect changes in legislation and University policy, and to incorporate emerging examples of good practice.

Version	Date	Summary of changes	Author
1.0	Oct 2026	Initial publication	CTL and AICC